

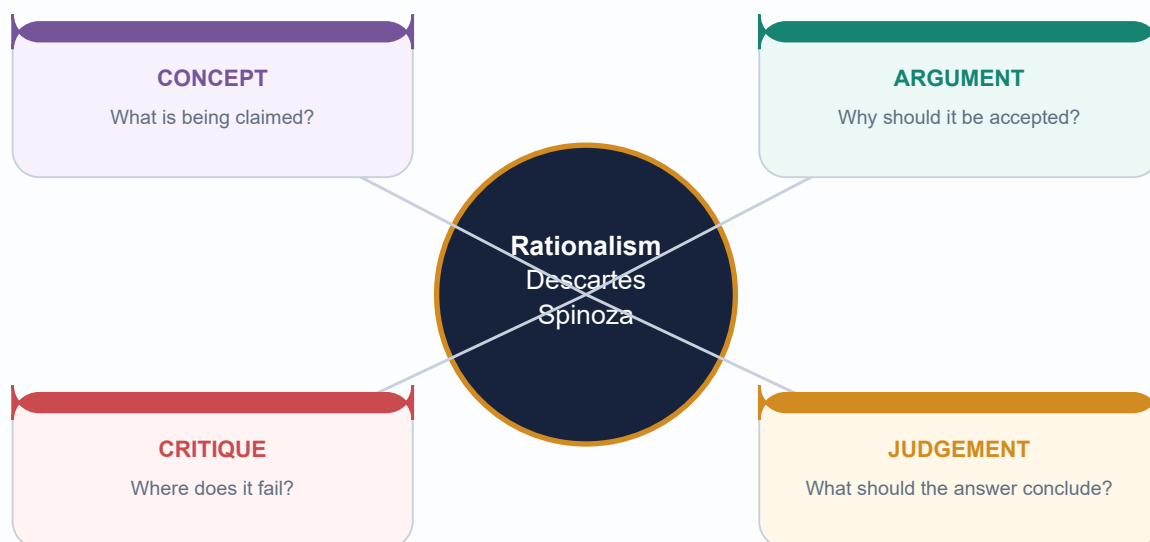
UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

Rationalism — Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz — Complete Visual Notes

UPSC Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Syllabus: Cartesian Method and Certain Knowledge; Substance; God; Mind–Body Dualism; Determinism and Freedom.

Direct local-book analysis • Verified knowledge cross-check • PYQ-mapped answer writing



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Master Map, Context and Technical Vocabulary

Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Seventeenth-century rationalism seeks mathematical certainty through reason, while its three major systems diverge over how many substances reality contains.

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

TIMELINE

1637 — Descartes publishes Discourse on Method

1641 — Meditations develops doubt, cogito and dualism

1677 — Spinoza's Ethics appears posthumously

1714 — Leibniz's Monadology summarises monadism

WHOLE-TOPIC DOCTRINE MAP

RATIONALISM — DESCARTES, SPINOZA AND LEIBNIZ

Method Doubt → cogito → clear and distinct perception	Substance Descartes 3; Spinoza 1; Leibniz indefinitely many
Mind–body Interaction, parallelism and pre-established harmony	Freedom Libertarian will, necessity and compatibilism

KEY DATA

Term	Precise Meaning	Answer Use
Cogito	Indubitable self-certainty in thinking	Start method questions
Substance	What exists independently	Compare the 3–1–many sequence
Attribute / mode	Ways substance is understood / modified	Explain Spinoza precisely
Monad	Simple, unextended centre of perception	Explain Leibnizian pluralism
Pre-established harmony	Non-causal coordination instituted by God	Answer mind–body questions

STATIC THEORY

- **Syllabus coverage:** Cartesian Method and Certain Knowledge; Substance; God; Mind–Body Dualism; Determinism and Freedom.
- **Intellectual context:** Seventeenth-century rationalism seeks mathematical certainty through reason, while its three major systems diverge over how many substances reality contains.
- **Source discipline:** claims were reconciled with the verified topic note, recent PYQs and the directly read local books listed below.
- **Theme cross-check:** substance, a priori knowledge and critiques of metaphysics were checked where relevant.

MEMORY HOOK

3–1–∞: Descartes' created dualism, Spinoza's one substance, Leibniz's plurality of monads.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Define each technical term before evaluating it.
2. Reconstruct the internal argument, not merely the conclusion.
3. Distinguish the thinker's own doctrine from a later label or criticism.
4. Use comparisons only after identifying the shared philosophical problem.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

WRONG: Monads exchange causal influence.

CORRECT: They are windowless; order is pre-established.

CROSS-SYLLABUS CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Rationalist substance	Aristotle and empiricism	Trace the changing bearer of properties
Cogito	Hume and Husserl	Compare substantial self, bundle and transcendental ego
Causality	Hume–Kant	Rational necessity meets empiricist scepticism
God	Philosophy of Religion	Ontological and causal proofs recur in Paper II

MAINS ANGLE

Open with the problem that generates the doctrine; end by judging its explanatory gain against its strongest internal cost.

STUDY LINK

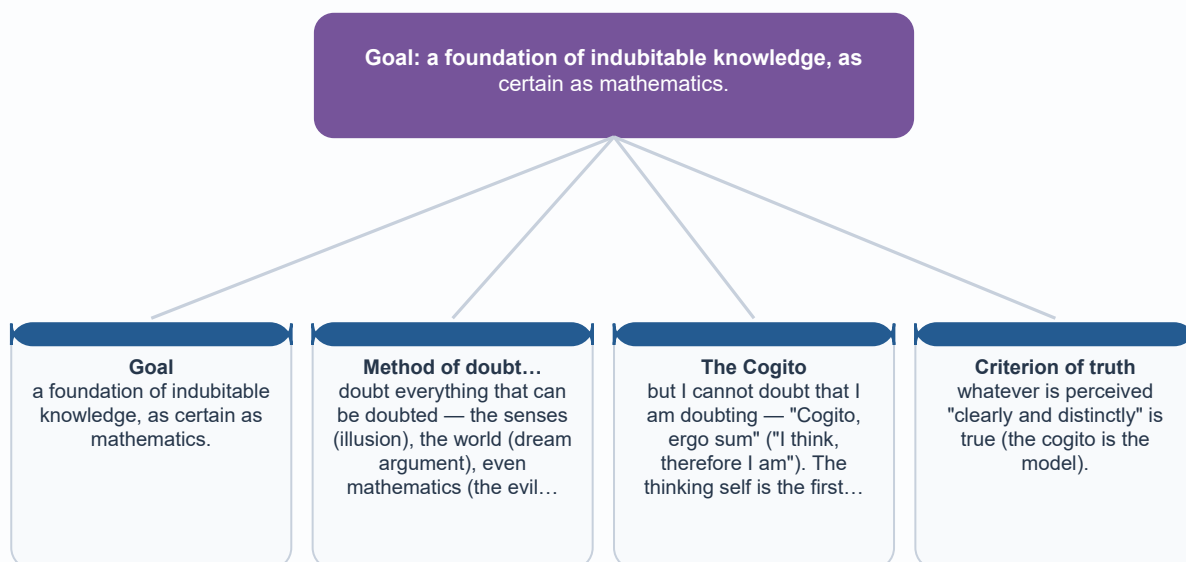
Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH**1. DESCARTES — METHOD & CERTAIN KNOWLEDGE**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Goal: a foundation of indubitable knowledge, as certain as mathematics.

*Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.*

1. DESCARTES — METHOD & CERTAIN KNOWLEDGE — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



STATIC THEORY

- Goal: a foundation of indubitable knowledge, as certain as mathematics.
- Method of doubt (methodic/hyperbolic doubt): doubt everything that can be doubted — the senses (illusion), the world (dream argument), even mathematics (the evil demon/genius could deceive).
- The Cogito: but I cannot doubt that I am doubting — "Cogito, ergo sum" ("I think, therefore I am"). The thinking self is the first indubitable certainty — the Archimedean point.
- Criterion of truth: whatever is perceived "clearly and distinctly" is true (the cogito is the model).
- Rebuilding knowledge: from the cogito → prove God (see §3) → God is no deceiver → therefore clear-and-distinct ideas (incl. the external world, mathematics) are trustworthy.
- The Cartesian Circle (stock objection): he uses clear-and-distinct ideas to prove God, then uses God to guarantee clear-and-distinct ideas — circular.

MEMORY HOOK

3–1–∞: Descartes' created dualism, Spinoza's one substance, Leibniz's plurality of monads.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Goal: a foundation of indubitable knowledge, as certain as mathematics.
2. Method of doubt (methodic/hyperbolic doubt): doubt everything that can be doubted — the senses (illusion), the world (dream argument), even mathematics (the evil demon/genius could deceive).
3. The Cogito: but I cannot doubt that I am doubting — "Cogito, ergo sum" ("I think, therefore I am"). The thinking self is the first indubitable certainty — the Archimedean point.
4. Criterion of truth: whatever is perceived "clearly and distinctly" is true (the cogito is the model).

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH

2. SUBSTANCE — the trio compared (STAR sub-topic, asked repeatedly) — Part 1

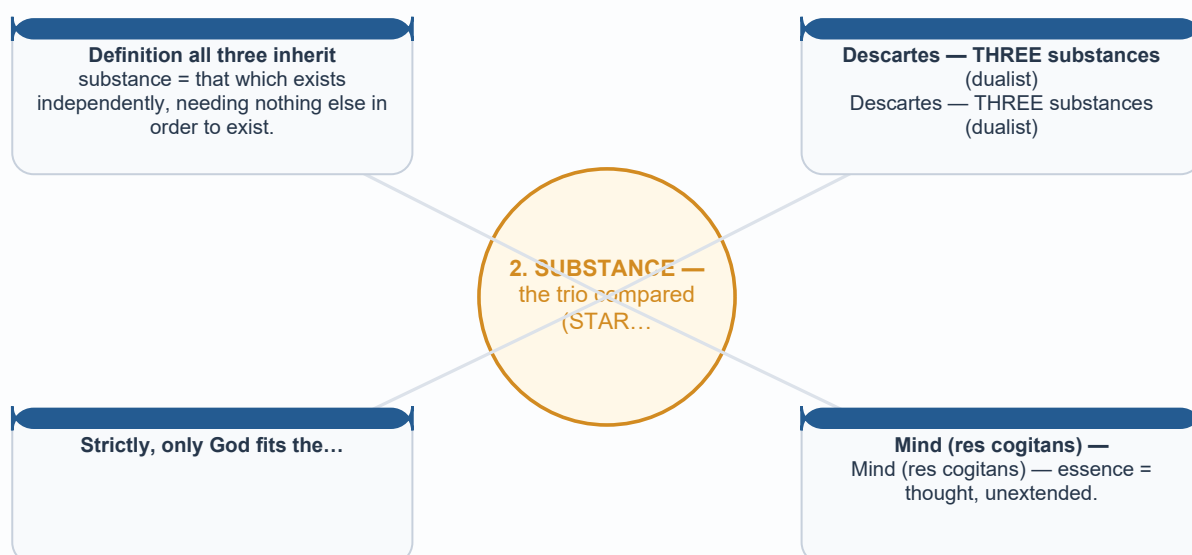
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Definition all three inherit: substance = that which exists independently, needing nothing else in order to exist.

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

2. SUBSTANCE — THE TRIO COMPARED (STAR SUB-TOPIC, ASKED REPEATEDLY) — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE

**STATIC THEORY**

- Definition all three inherit: substance = that which exists independently, needing nothing else in order to exist.
- **Descartes — THREE substances (dualist)**
- Strictly, only God fits the definition (needs nothing); but created substances are of two kinds:
 - Mind (res cogitans) — essence = thought, unextended.
 - Matter (res extensa) — essence = extension, unthinking.
- Tension: by his own definition only God is a substance; calling mind & matter "substances" is a concession.
- **Spinoza — ONE substance (monist/pantheist)**

MEMORY HOOK

CLAIM → REASON → CONSEQUENCE → OBJECTION → QUALIFIED REPLY.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Definition all three inherit: substance = that which exists independently, needing nothing else in order to exist.
2. Descartes — THREE substances (dualist)
3. Strictly, only God fits the definition (needs nothing); but created substances are of two kinds:
4. Mind (res cogitans) — essence = thought, unextended.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH**2. SUBSTANCE — the trio compared (STAR sub-topic, asked repeatedly) — Part 2**

Paper I Western Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Applies the definition rigorously: if substance needs nothing else, there can be only ONE — infinite, self-caused (causa sui) = God = Nature (Deus sive Natura).

Continuation: preserve the full semantic chain before moving to criticism.

2. SUBSTANCE — THE TRIO COMPARED (STAR SUB-TOPIC, ASKED REPEATEDLY) — REASONING SEQUENCE**1. Applies the definition rigorously**

if substance needs nothing else, there can be only ONE — infinite, self-caused (causa sui) = God = Nature (Deus sive Natura).

**2. Mind and matter are**

Mind and matter are not substances but two of God's infinite attributes (Thought & Extension) that we can know.

**3. Individual things (incl. us)**

Individual things (incl. us) = modes (modifications) of the one substance.

**4. This directly answers 2024**

This directly answers 2024 P-II Q6b ("God embedded in Spinoza's metaphysics of substance & attributes").

STATIC THEORY

- Applies the definition rigorously: if substance needs nothing else, there can be only ONE — infinite, self-caused (causa sui) = God = Nature (Deus sive Natura).
- Mind and matter are not substances but two of God's infinite attributes (Thought & Extension) that we can know.
- Individual things (incl. us) = modes (modifications) of the one substance.
- This directly answers 2024 P-II Q6b ("God embedded in Spinoza's metaphysics of substance & attributes").
- **Leibniz — INFINITE substances (pluralist)**
- Reality = infinitely many monads — simple, unextended, windowless ("no windows" = they don't causally interact), soul-like centres of force/perception.
- Each monad mirrors the whole universe from its viewpoint; they form a graded hierarchy up to God (the supreme Monad).

MEMORY HOOK

CLAIM → REASON → CONSEQUENCE → OBJECTION → QUALIFIED REPLY.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Applies the definition rigorously: if substance needs nothing else, there can be only ONE — infinite, self-caused (causa sui) = God = Nature (Deus sive Natura).
2. Mind and matter are not substances but two of God's infinite attributes (Thought & Extension) that we can know.
3. Individual things (incl. us) = modes (modifications) of the one substance.
4. This directly answers 2024 P-II Q6b ("God embedded in Spinoza's metaphysics of substance & attributes").

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH

2. SUBSTANCE — the trio compared (STAR sub-topic, asked repeatedly) — Part 3

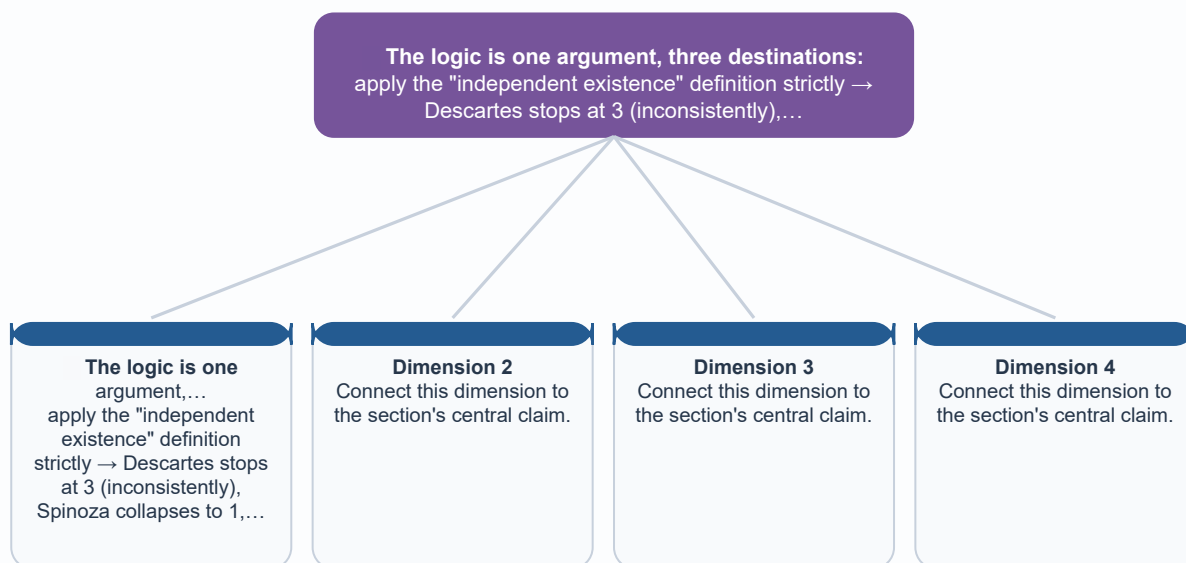
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The logic is one argument, three destinations: apply the "independent existence" definition strictly → Descartes stops at 3 (inconsistently), Spinoza collapses to 1, Leibniz explodes to ∞. Show this and you own the substance question.

Continuation: preserve the full semantic chain before moving to criticism.

2. SUBSTANCE — THE TRIO COMPARED (STAR SUB-TOPIC, ASKED REPEATEDLY) — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



STATIC THEORY

- The logic is one argument, three destinations: apply the "independent existence" definition strictly → Descartes stops at 3 (inconsistently), Spinoza collapses to 1, Leibniz explodes to ∞ . Show this and you own the substance question.

MEMORY HOOK

3–1– ∞ : Descartes' created dualism, Spinoza's one substance, Leibniz's plurality of monads.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

- The logic is one argument, three destinations: apply the "independent existence" definition strictly → Descartes stops at 3 (inconsistently), Spinoza collapses to 1, Leibniz explodes to ∞ . Show this and you own the...

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

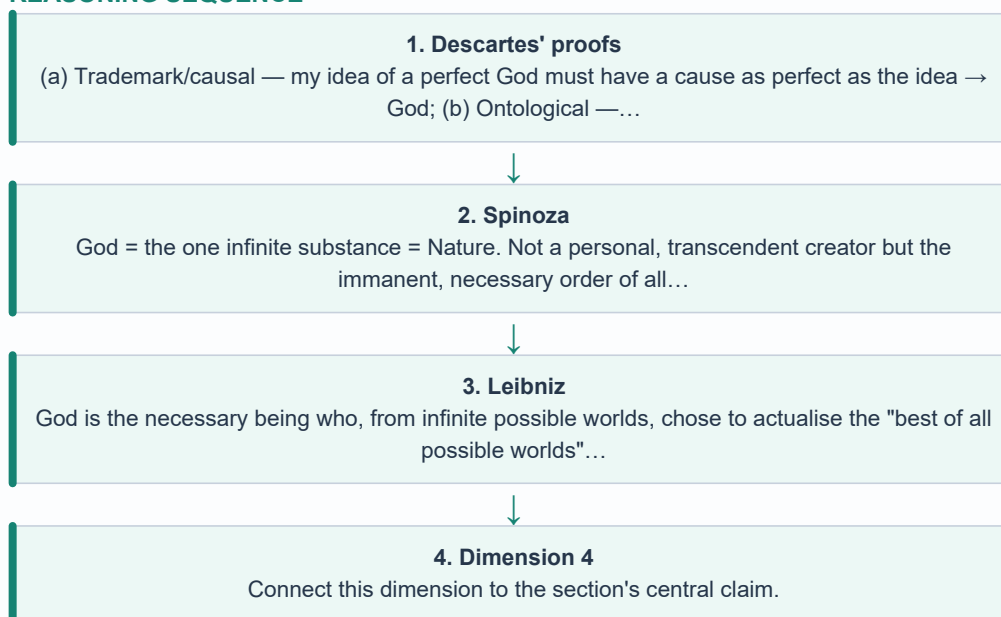
Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH

3. GODPaper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Descartes' proofs: (a) Trademark/causal — my idea of a perfect God must have a cause as perfect as the idea → God; (b) Ontological — perfection entails existence (a perfect being lacking existence is a contradiction).

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

3. GOD — REASONING SEQUENCE**STATIC THEORY**

- Descartes' proofs: (a) Trademark/causal — my idea of a perfect God must have a cause as perfect as the idea → God; (b) Ontological — perfection entails existence (a perfect being lacking existence is a contradiction).
- Spinoza: God = the one infinite substance = Nature. Not a personal, transcendent creator but the immanent, necessary order of all that is. Impersonal pantheism.
- Leibniz: God is the necessary being who, from infinite possible worlds, chose to actualise the "best of all possible worlds" (principle of sufficient reason + optimism). Sets up the pre-established harmony.

MEMORY HOOK

3–1–∞: Descartes' created dualism, Spinoza's one substance, Leibniz's plurality of monads.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Descartes' proofs: (a) Trademark/causal — my idea of a perfect God must have a cause as perfect as the idea → God; (b) Ontological — perfection entails existence (a perfect being lacking existence is a contradiction).
2. Spinoza: God = the one infinite substance = Nature. Not a personal, transcendent creator but the immanent, necessary order of all that is. Impersonal pantheism.
3. Leibniz: God is the necessary being who, from infinite possible worlds, chose to actualise the "best of all possible worlds" (principle of sufficient reason + optimism). Sets up the pre-established harmony.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

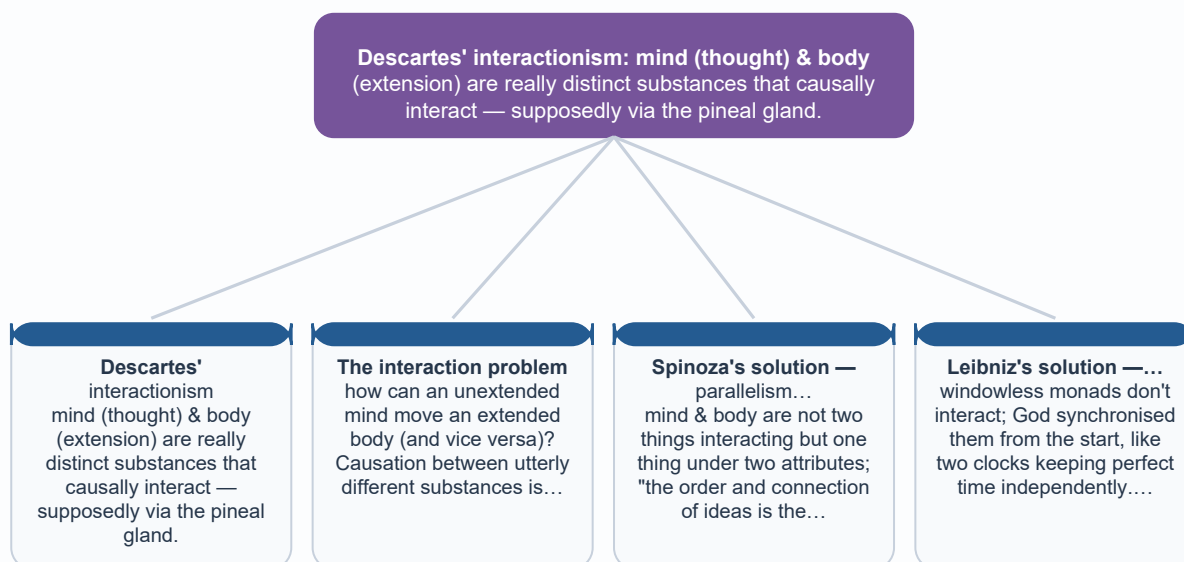
STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH**4. MIND–BODY PROBLEM**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Descartes' interactionism: mind (thought) & body (extension) are really distinct substances that causally interact — supposedly via the pineal gland.

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

4. MIND–BODY PROBLEM — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE**STATIC THEORY**

- Descartes' interactionism: mind (thought) & body (extension) are really distinct substances that causally interact — supposedly via the pineal gland.
- The interaction problem: how can an unextended mind move an extended body (and vice versa)? Causation between utterly different substances is unintelligible. → the central objection to dualism.
- Spinoza's solution — parallelism (double-aspect): mind & body are not two things interacting but one thing under two attributes; "the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things." No interaction needed.
- Leibniz's solution — pre-established harmony: windowless monads don't interact; God synchronised them from the start, like two clocks keeping perfect time independently. Mind and body only seem to interact.

MEMORY HOOK

3–1–∞: Descartes' created dualism, Spinoza's one substance, Leibniz's plurality of monads.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Descartes' interactionism: mind (thought) & body (extension) are really distinct substances that causally interact — supposedly via the pineal gland.
2. The interaction problem: how can an unextended mind move an extended body (and vice versa)? Causation between utterly different substances is unintelligible. → the central objection to dualism.
3. Spinoza's solution — parallelism (double-aspect): mind & body are not two things interacting but one thing under two attributes; "the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things." No...
4. Leibniz's solution — pre-established harmony: windowless monads don't interact; God synchronised them from the start, like two clocks keeping perfect time independently. Mind and body only seem to interact.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

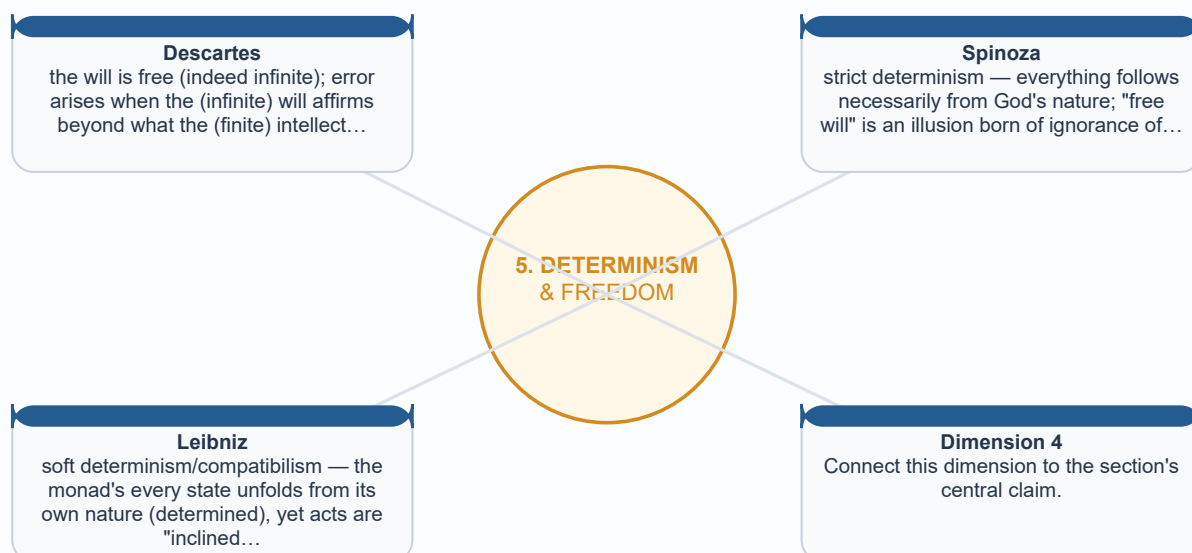
STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH**5. DETERMINISM & FREEDOM**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Descartes: the will is free (indeed infinite); error arises when the (infinite) will affirms beyond what the (finite) intellect clearly perceives. Libertarian on the mind.

*Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.*

5. DETERMINISM & FREEDOM — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE

STATIC THEORY

- Descartes: the will is free (indeed infinite); error arises when the (infinite) will affirms beyond what the (finite) intellect clearly perceives. Libertarian on the mind.
- Spinoza: strict determinism — everything follows necessarily from God's nature; "free will" is an illusion born of ignorance of causes. Freedom = understanding necessity (acting from adequate ideas, not being externally compelled). Freedom ≠ contingency but self-determination through reason.
- Leibniz: soft determinism/compatibilism — the monad's every state unfolds from its own nature (determined), yet acts are "inclined without being necessitated"; freedom = spontaneity + intelligence + contingency (this world is chosen, not logically necessary).

MEMORY HOOK

3–1–∞: Descartes' created dualism, Spinoza's one substance, Leibniz's plurality of monads.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Descartes: the will is free (indeed infinite); error arises when the (infinite) will affirms beyond what the (finite) intellect clearly perceives. Libertarian on the mind.
2. Spinoza: strict determinism — everything follows necessarily from God's nature; "free will" is an illusion born of ignorance of causes. Freedom = understanding necessity (acting from adequate ideas, not being...)
3. Leibniz: soft determinism/compatibilism — the monad's every state unfolds from its own nature (determined), yet acts are "inclined without being necessitated"; freedom = spontaneity + intelligence + contingency (this...)

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Descartes simply doubts everything permanently.

CORRECT: His doubt is methodological and aims at reconstruction.

WRONG: Spinoza's God is a personal creator outside nature.

CORRECT: God is the one immanent substance: Deus sive Natura.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH

Criticisms, Replies, Comparisons and Verified Statement Bank

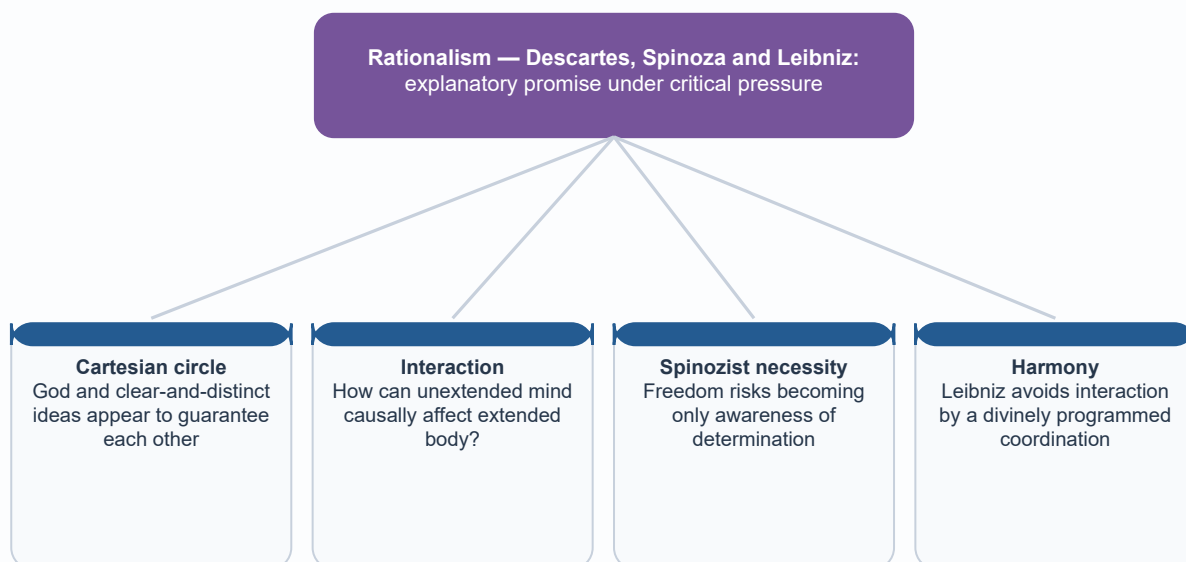
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

A high-scoring critical answer distinguishes an external rejection from an immanent objection and gives the strongest available reply before judging the doctrine.

Statement bank retained only where the verified local topic file marks the wording as canonical; all other formulations are treated as paraphrase.

CLAIM–OBJECTION–REPLY ARCHITECTURE



KEY DATA

Axis	Descartes	Spinoza	Leibniz
Substances	3 (God, mind, matter)	1 (God=Nature)	∞ (monads)
God	personal, transcendent	impersonal, immanent (pantheism)	necessary, chose best world
Mind-body	interaction (pineal)	parallelism	pre-established harmony
Freedom	free will	freedom = understanding necessity	compatibilism
Method	doubt → cogito	geometric (Ethics more geometrico)	principle of sufficient reason

STATIC THEORY

- **Critical pressure:** Cartesian circle — God and clear-and-distinct ideas appear to guarantee each other
- **Critical pressure:** Interaction — How can unextended mind causally affect extended body?
- **Critical pressure:** Spinozist necessity — Freedom risks becoming only awareness of determination
- **Critical pressure:** Harmony — Leibniz avoids interaction by a divinely programmed coordination

MEMORY HOOK

C-O-R-J: CLAIM → strongest OBJECTION → plausible REPLY → reasoned JUDGEMENT.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. "Cogito, ergo sum" — Descartes.
2. "Deus sive Natura" (God, or Nature) — Spinoza.
3. "The order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things." — Spinoza.
4. "Monads have no windows through which anything could come in or go out." — Leibniz.
5. "This is the best of all possible worlds." — Leibniz.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Criticism means listing hostile names.

CORRECT: State the objection's premise, target and consequence.

WRONG: A quotation can replace exposition.

CORRECT: Unpack the statement's technical meaning and argumentative role.

WRONG: Comparison is two separate summaries.

CORRECT: Compare axis-by-axis around a shared problem.

COMPARATIVE ROUTES

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Rationalist substance	Aristotle and empiricism	Trace the changing bearer of properties
Cogito	Hume and Husserl	Compare substantial self, bundle and transcendental ego
Causality	Hume–Kant	Rational necessity meets empiricist scepticism
God	Philosophy of Religion	Ontological and causal proofs recur in Paper II

MAINS ANGLE

Use the statement as a compressed argument: define its terms, reconstruct what follows, stage the strongest objection and give a qualified verdict.

STUDY LINK

Verified knowledge file: [Rationalism.md](#) •

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 104–145 (Descartes and Spinoza); Cambridge Dictionary, PDF pp. 524–527 (Leibniz); Masih contents identify chs. 2–4, but the local file contains contents pages only.

HIGH**PYQs, Applied Drills and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Architecture**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The final layer converts doctrine into directive-sensitive answers. Keep exposition proportionate to marks, reserve space for criticism and end with a qualified philosophical judgement.

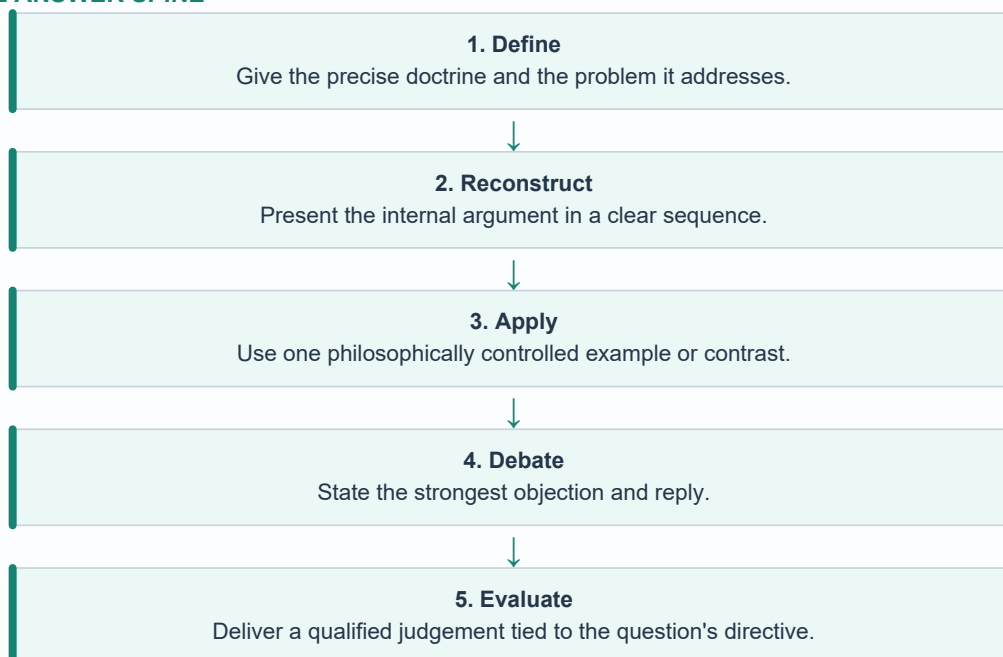
PYQs reproduced from the local UPSC Western Philosophy bank for 2022–2025; wording is shortened only in the table, not altered in doctrinal demand.

RECENT DIRECT PYQ YIELD



KEY DATA

Year	Verified Demand	Marks
2025	Basic tenets of rationalism and Descartes' system	20
2025	Spinoza: all determination is negation	15
2024	Rationalists on mind–body and freedom	15
2024	Spinoza: whatever is, is in God	15
2023	Spinoza on freedom and determinism	10
2023	Descartes' innate ideas and Locke's reply	15
2022	Spinoza's substance and pantheism	15
2022	Cartesian certainty of self and world	15

D-R-A-D-E ANSWER SPINE**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** 2-line context; define the key term; 3–4 linked doctrinal points; one precise objection; 2-line judgement.
- **15 marks:** establish the problem; reconstruct the argument with technical vocabulary; add comparison or example; objection–reply; balanced conclusion.
- **20 marks:** map every syllabus dimension in the question; develop the derivation; compare alternatives; stage two critical pressures; defend or qualify; conclude with an explicit criterion of success.
- [Compare — the classic] "Compare the conceptions of substance in Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz."
- [Method] "Discuss Descartes' method of doubt and the cogito as certain knowledge."
- [Mind-body] "Examine the Cartesian mind-body problem and the solutions of Spinoza and Leibniz."
- [Freedom] "'Freedom is the recognition of necessity.' Discuss with reference to Spinoza."
- [Cross-paper] "How is God embedded in Spinoza's metaphysics of substance and attributes?" (2024 P-II Q6b).
- **9.1 — "Compare the conceptions of substance in Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz." (recurring, asked ~every year)**
 - Frame : shared definition (independent existence) → three destinations.
 - Body : Descartes 3 (dualist, tension) → Spinoza 1 (strict → pantheism) → Leibniz ∞ (monads).
 - Link : each substance-view dictates the mind-body solution (interaction/parallelism/harmony).
 - Assess: Descartes inconsistent; Spinoza logically tightest but impersonal; Leibniz saves plurality at cost of ad-hoc harmony.
 - Concl : one definition, rigorously applied, drives the whole of Continental Rationalism.
- **9.2 — "How is God embedded in Spinoza's metaphysics of substance and attributes?" (2024 P-II Q6b, 15m)**
 - Intro : Spinoza defines substance as self-caused, independent → only ONE possible = God.

MEMORY HOOK

MARKS CONTROL DEPTH: 10 = compact argument; 15 = argument + debate; 20 = complete architecture + sustained evaluation.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The directive determines emphasis: explain, examine, compare and evaluate are not interchangeable.
2. A 20-mark answer must show relations among subparts, not merely add more bullet points.
3. Use one stable example through exposition and criticism where possible.
4. Conclusions should identify what the doctrine successfully explains and what remains unresolved.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Memorise one essay for every wording.

CORRECT: Adapt the same doctrine map to the directive and marks.

WRONG: Criticism should occupy most of the answer.

CORRECT: Secure accurate exposition before proportionate evaluation.

WRONG: A conclusion merely repeats the introduction.

CORRECT: It must state a defended philosophical judgement.

MAINS ANGLE

For statement questions, treat the quotation as a claim needing reconstruction; for comparison, organise by axes; for 'does it solve' questions, state an explicit success criterion.

STUDY LINK

Official local PYQ bank:

[_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2022-2025.md](#)

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI